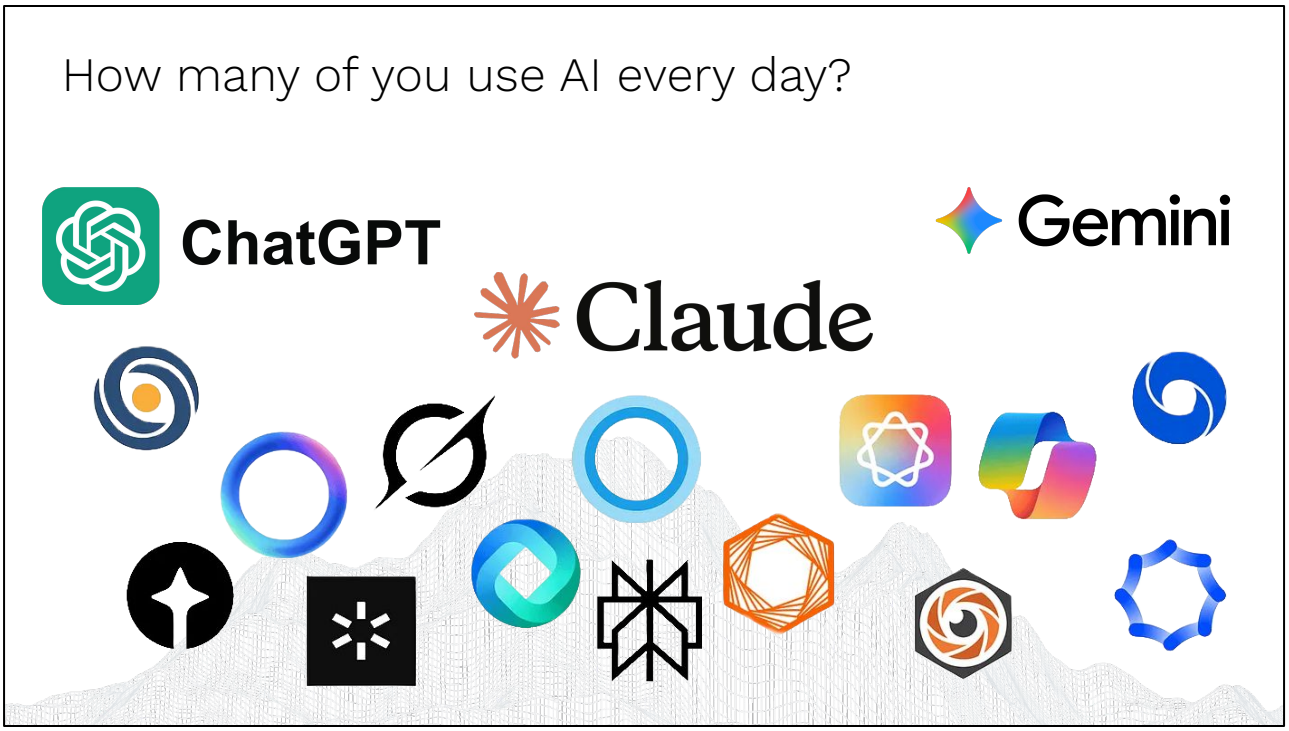


Thanks everyone for joining today. What I wanted to explore in this session is not just how we use AI tools, but how AI changes the way we think while we work.

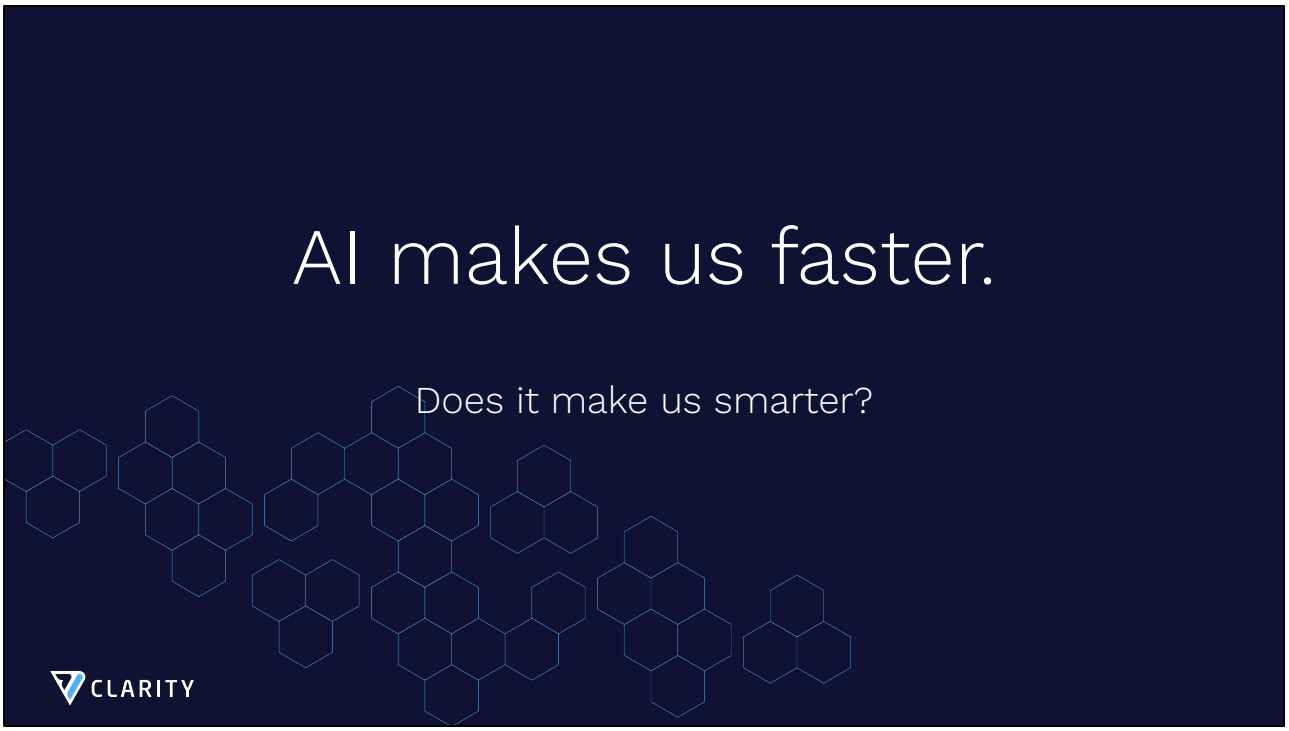
The more I've worked with these systems, the more I've realized the real challenge isn't getting people to use AI. Most of us are already using it constantly. The challenge is understanding where AI helps us think better and where it might actually create overconfidence without deeper understanding. That's really what today's discussion is about.



I wanted to start with a quick pulse check because I think this tells us a lot about where we are already as an industry.

How many of you are using AI every day at this point? Probably almost everyone. And not just casually, but in actual workflows. Writing requirements, summarizing meetings, brainstorming ideas, reviewing code, creating documentation, organizing thoughts.

What's interesting is how quickly this shifted from being experimental to becoming normal workflow behavior. We're not really debating whether AI belongs in our workflows anymore. It already does. The question now is how we use it responsibly and thoughtfully.

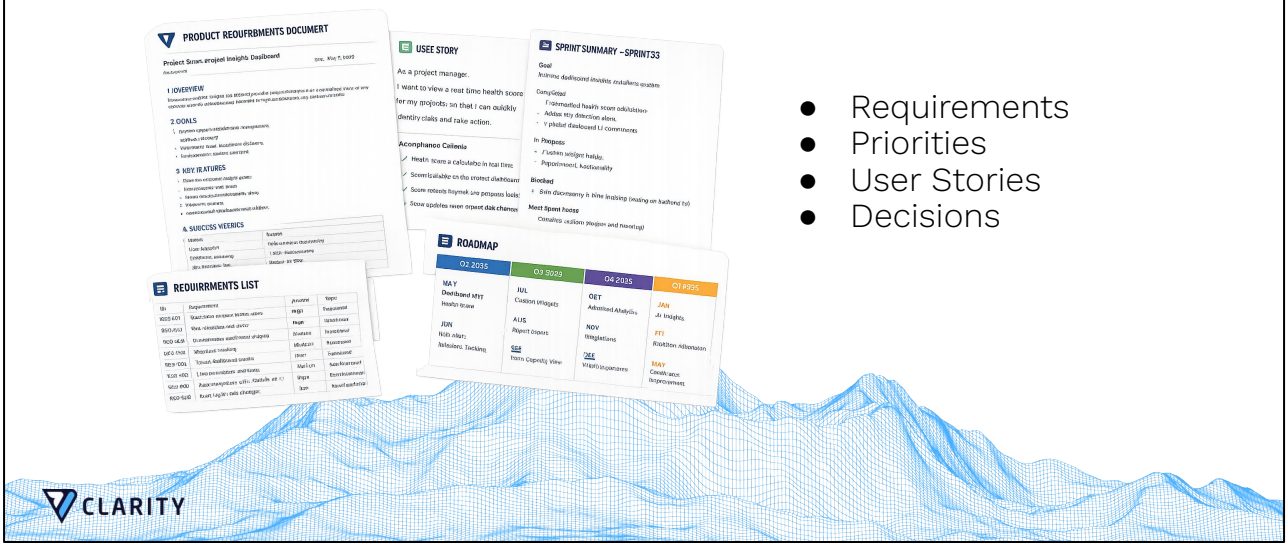


I think this slide captures the tension I keep coming back to. AI absolutely makes us faster. There's no question about that. I use it constantly myself, and honestly it has changed the way I work.

But speed and understanding are not necessarily the same thing. Sometimes AI gives us the feeling of clarity before we've actually done the deeper thinking ourselves. And because the outputs are usually polished and confident sounding, it becomes easy to mistake fluency for expertise.

That's where I think the real risk starts showing up, especially in product management where so much of our work involves judgment, prioritization, communication, and decision-making.

What parts of our thinking process are we starting to outsource?



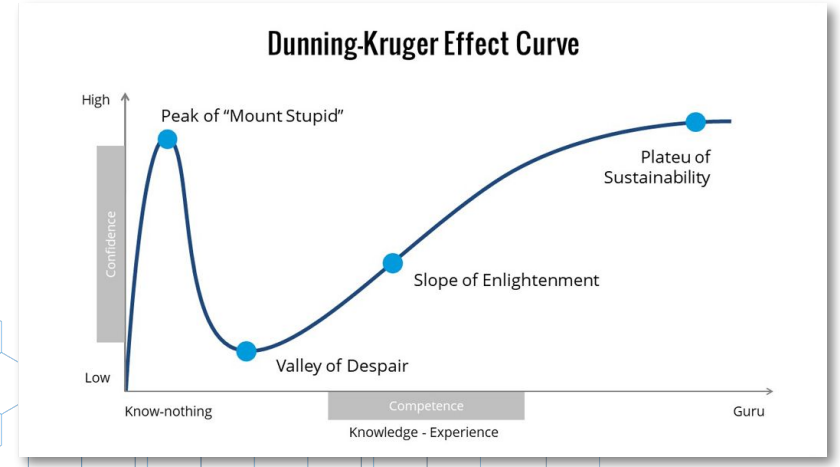
- Requirements
- Priorities
- User Stories
- Decisions

One thing I started realizing is that we're beginning to trust AI with increasingly important parts of our work. Not just small tasks, but actual thinking work. Requirements. Prioritization. User stories. Stakeholder summaries. Recommendations.

And the outputs are often really good. That's what makes this complicated. They're polished, structured, and professional. But polished doesn't necessarily mean correct.

The more I thought about it, the more I realized the real issue isn't whether AI makes mistakes. Humans make mistakes too. The issue is whether we still recognize where critical thinking and validation are required.

The Dunning-Kruger Effect

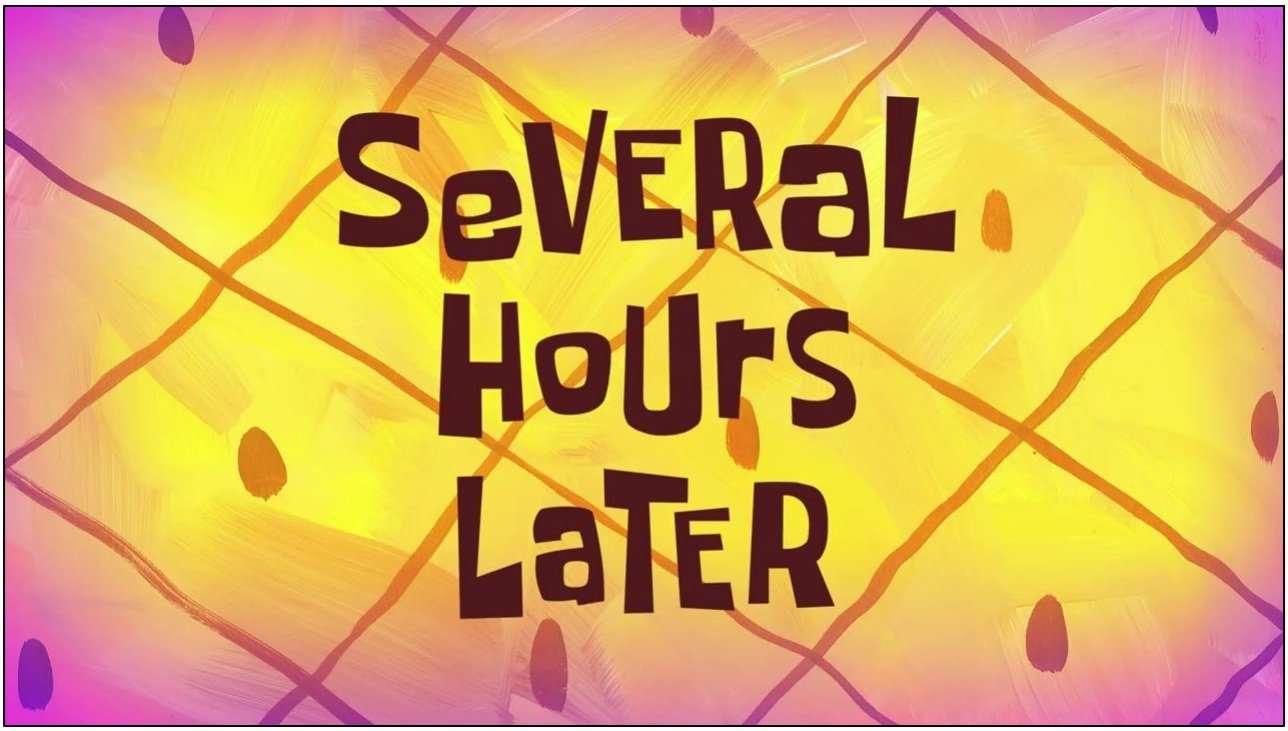


CLARITY

The Dunning-Kruger effect is basically the idea that people sometimes overestimate their understanding when they only have partial knowledge.

And honestly, this is a completely human thing. Everyone experiences it at some point.

Usually the more we learn about something, the more we realize how much complexity actually exists underneath it.



I've actually experienced this in my own career in a way that really changed how I think about collaboration and assumptions.

I was a product manager at my previous company for about 13 years, but we didn't really have deeply integrated UX teams inside our product teams. UX existed, but it felt more separated from day-to-day product work.

Then after leaving that company, I worked at the VA before coming to Clarity, and it was the first time I experienced what I would consider a truly balanced cross-functional team.

I remember being in a discussion about something simple, like where to place a button on a screen. And honestly, my mindset at the time was:

"Well… there's probably just a logical place for the button."

I assumed good design was mostly common sense.

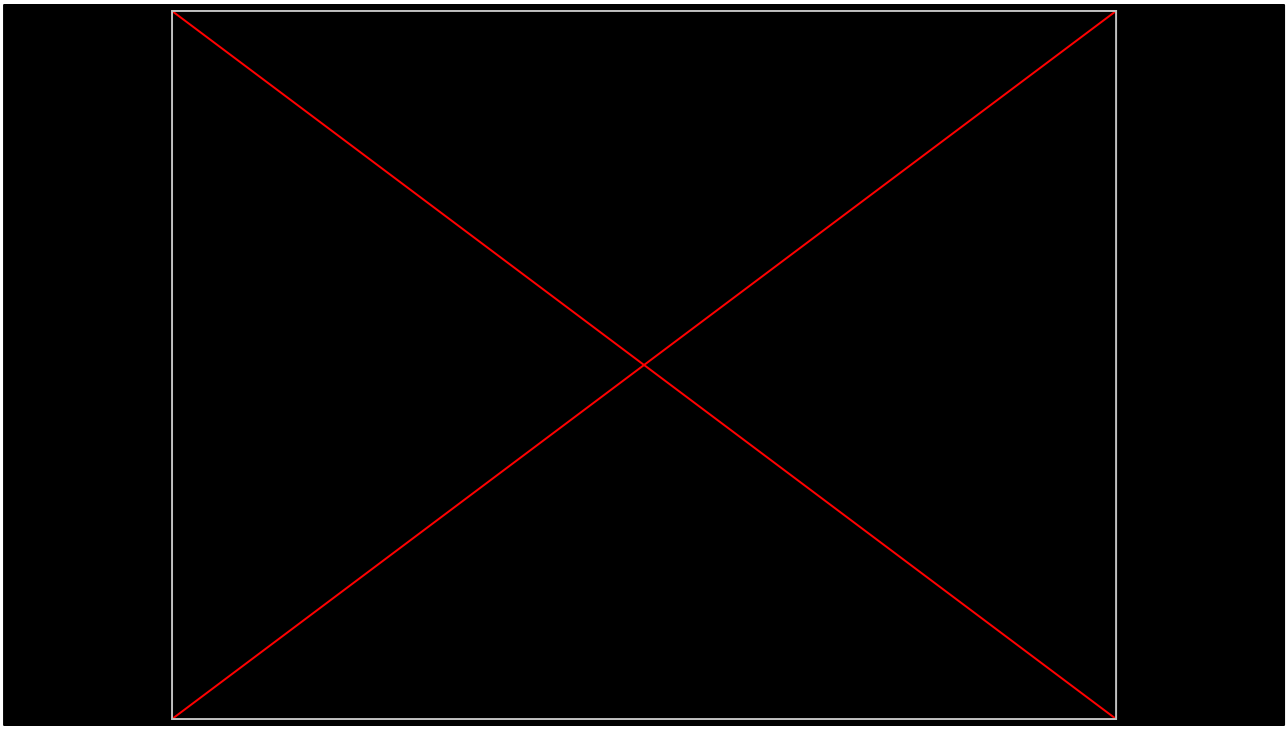
But then I sat in with the UX researchers, the designers, and actual veterans using the product, and it completely changed how I thought about user behavior.

People didn't interact with the system the way I assumed they would.

Things that felt obvious to me were not obvious to users at all.

And honestly, that was incredibly eye-opening because it made me realize how many assumptions I had mistaken for understanding.

That experience completely changed how I work now.

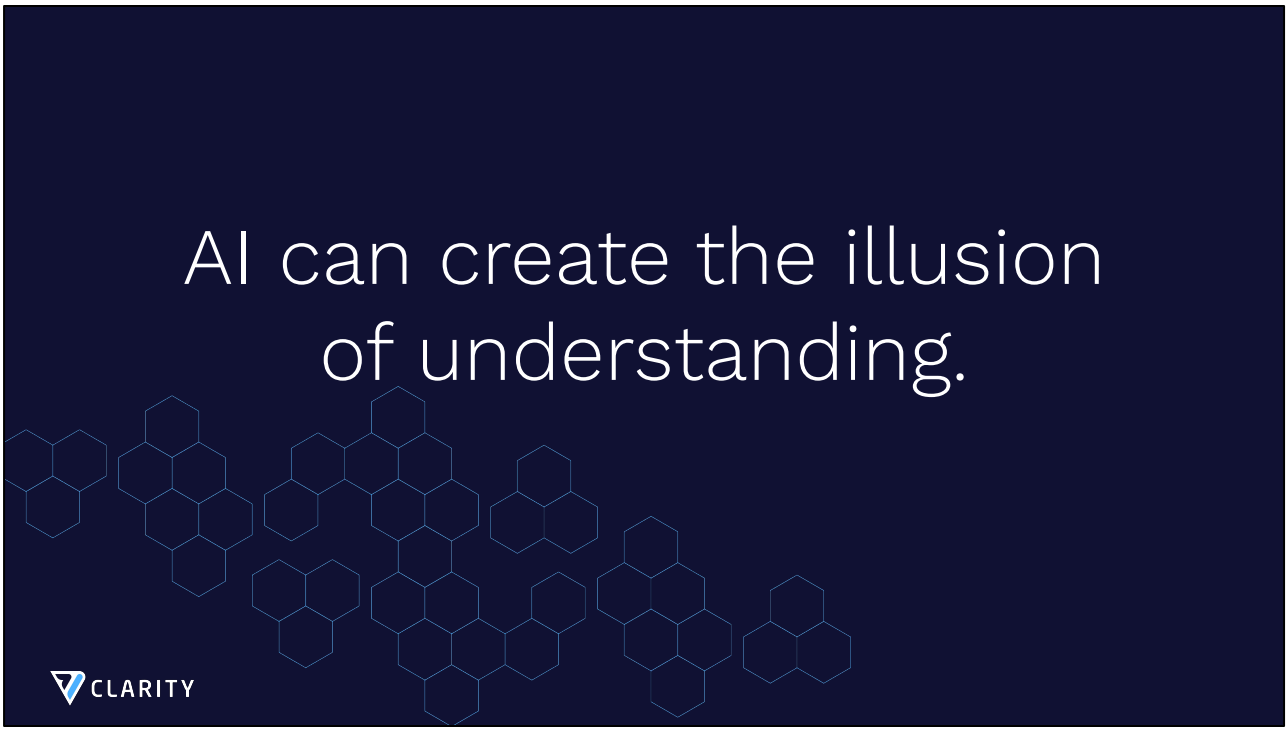


That experience really stayed with me because it changed how I think about expertise and confidence.

And honestly, I started noticing a very similar pattern while working with AI tools.

The faster and more capable these systems became, the easier it was to feel productive and confident very quickly, sometimes before I had fully thought through whether I actually understood the problem deeply myself.

I came across this short clip recently, and it articulated that feeling in a way that really resonated with me, especially the idea that AI can sometimes increase confidence faster than understanding.



AI systems are extremely good at sounding polished, structured, and confident. Sometimes they make us feel like we understand something more deeply than we actually do.

And that's not because people are unintelligent. It's because the systems themselves are incredibly fluent communicators.

The more I worked with AI-assisted workflows, the more I realized how easy it is to confuse output quality with actual understanding.

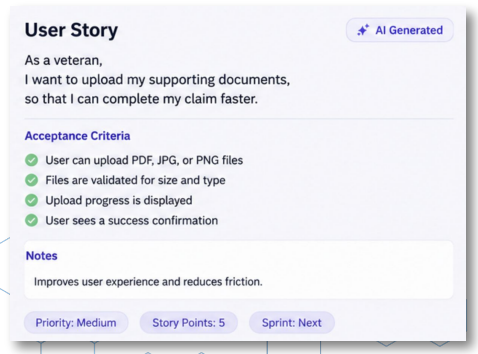
Sometimes we finish something quickly and assume that because the result looks good, our understanding must also be deep.

But speed and comprehension are not always the same thing.

The dangerous outputs are rarely obviously wrong.

Looks polished

Well-structured. Confident. Complete.



Fast to generate. Easy to trust.
But is it actually right?

Actually Risky

The issues are subtle, not obvious.

Vague requirements: "Supporting documents" is undefined. What documents? Any limits?

Hidden dependencies: Relies on document services, storage, and scanning capabilities.

Assumptions: Assumes all users have digital documents and know how to upload them.

Missing edge cases: What about poor connectivity, large files, accessibility needs, or errors?

No validation of real user needs: We haven't validated if this is the biggest pain point or the right solution.

Good PMs don't just consume AI output. We challenge it, validate it, and add the missing human judgment.

CLARITY

I think this is one of the biggest mindset shifts when working with AI in product workflows.

The dangerous outputs usually are not ridiculous hallucinations or obvious nonsense.

They’re mostly right.

They’re polished.

They’re structured well.

They sound confident.

Which is exactly why they can become risky.

In product management especially, AI-generated outputs can look complete while still containing important gaps underneath the surface.

Missing edge cases.

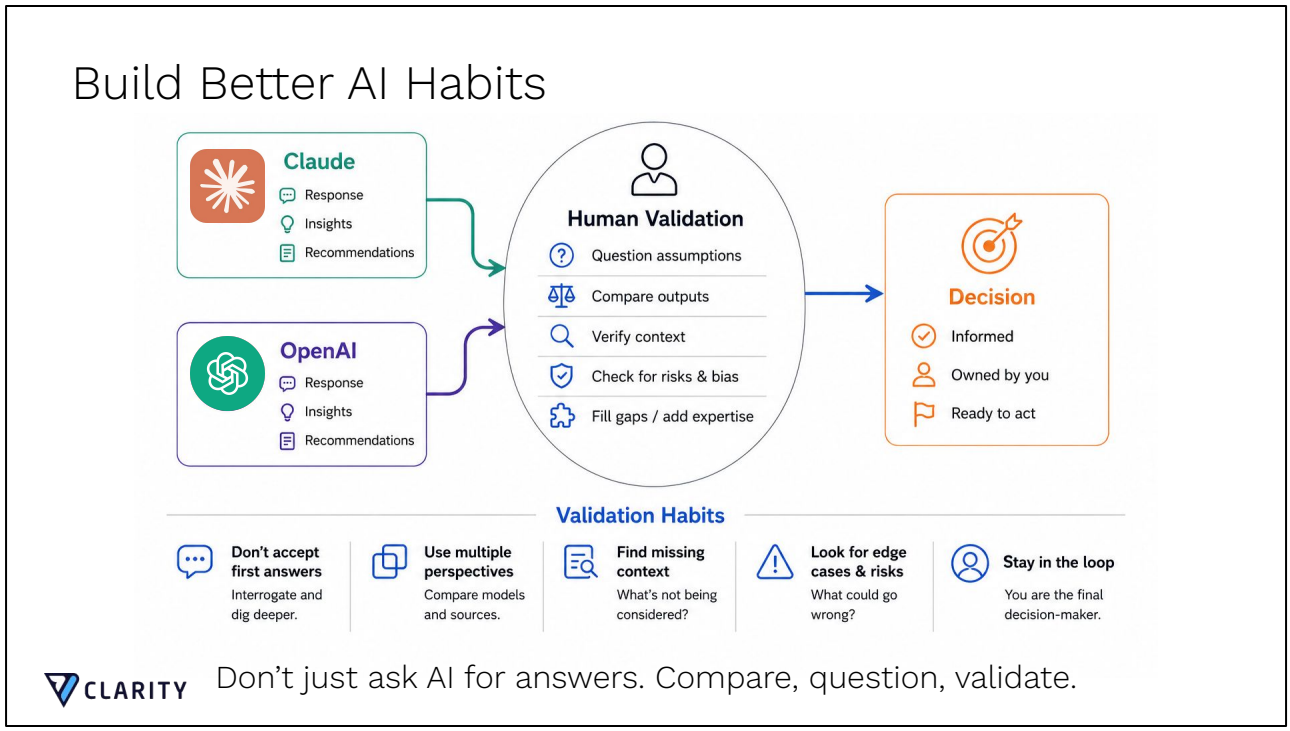
Weak assumptions.

Hidden dependencies.

Unvalidated user needs.

And honestly, those are the hardest problems to catch because nothing looks obviously broken.

The challenge becomes recognizing what’s missing rather than simply spotting obvious errors.



So if AI is becoming part of our workflows permanently, what habits do we need to build around it?

One thing I've personally started doing is intentionally comparing systems against each other. I'll use Claude alongside OpenAI Codex and see where they disagree or where one catches something the other missed.

That process has actually changed the way I think about AI.

I no longer think of it as asking a machine for answers. It feels more like facilitating a review conversation between multiple collaborators.

There's actually a South Park episode where Randy starts using ChatGPT to help communicate with Sharon, and the funny part is that ChatGPT basically just keeps reinforcing whatever he already thinks and telling him what he wants to hear.

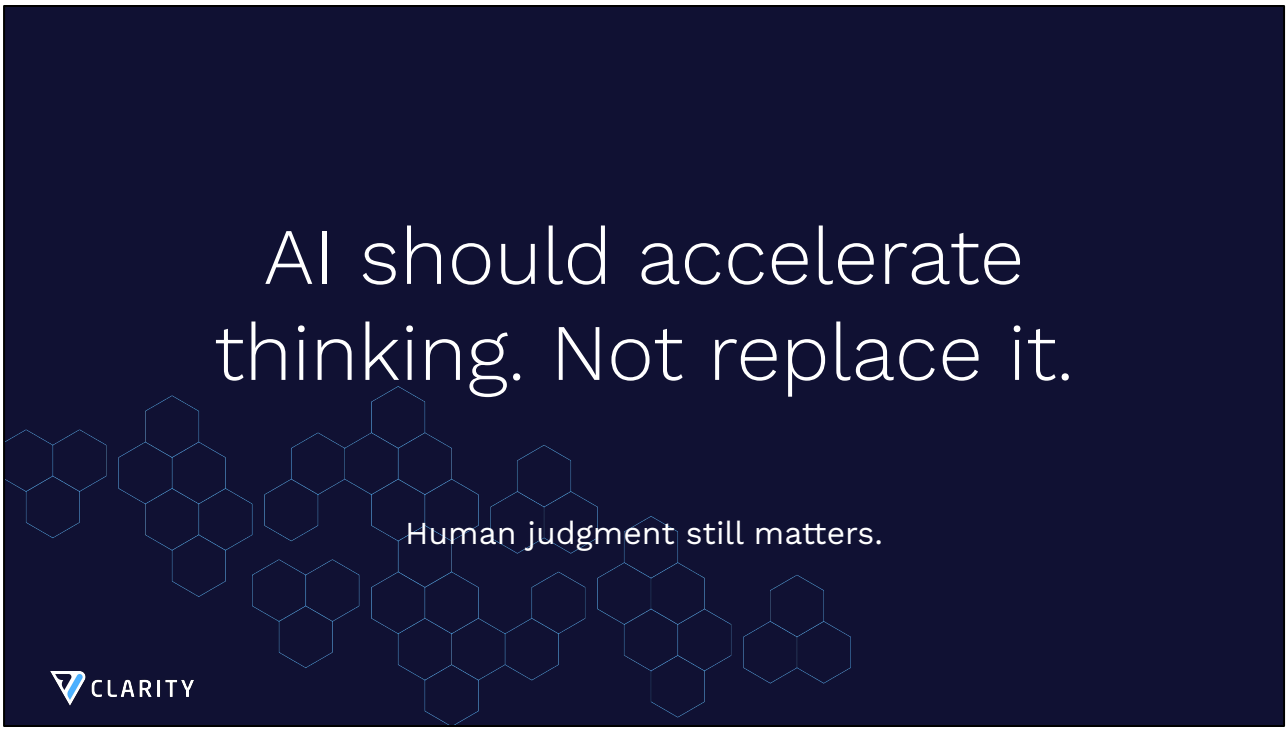
It's obviously exaggerated for comedy, but there's actually something important underneath that joke.

AI systems are often optimized to sound helpful, agreeable, and coherent, not necessarily to challenge our assumptions.

And honestly, that's part of why validation matters so much. If we only use AI to reinforce what we already believe, we can end up amplifying our blind spots instead of improving our thinking.

So now when I'm working with AI, I try to slow myself down and ask a few questions before immediately accepting an output just because it sounds polished.

What assumptions are being made here?

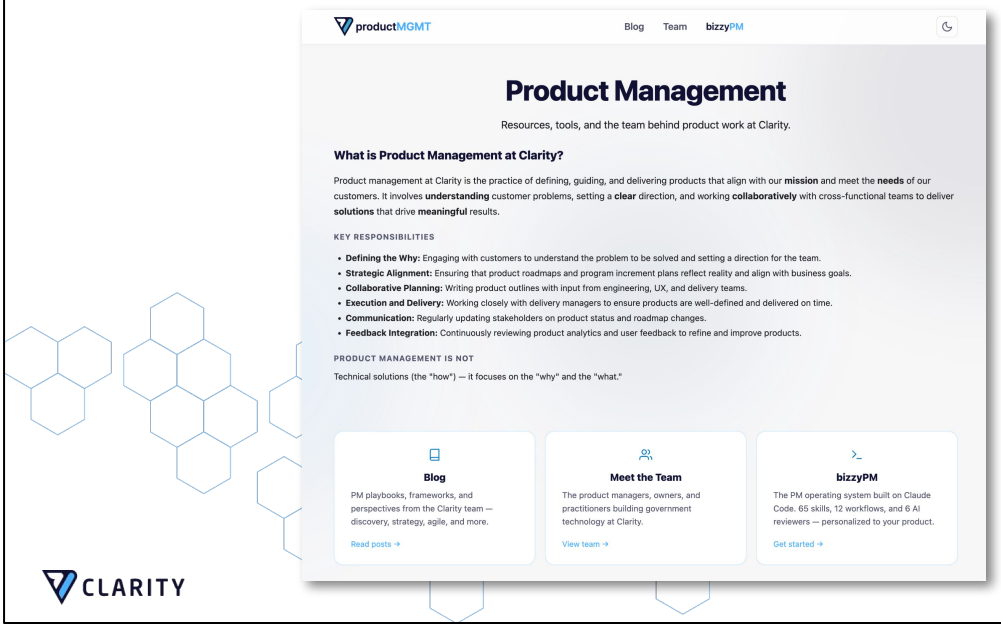


I want to be really clear that I am not anti-AI at all. I think AI is going to become foundational to almost every knowledge work discipline.

But I think we have to be intentional about preserving human judgment inside the workflow. AI should accelerate thinking, expand exploration, and reduce friction. It shouldn't replace critical thinking entirely.

The goal isn't resisting AI. The goal is using it thoughtfully and responsibly.I think the answer is designing workflows that keep people mentally engaged instead of becoming passive reviewers of AI output.

Claude Workflow Demo



So I want to shift from the concept side into something more practical.

I've been working on a set of Claude tools and skills to support product management work, especially things like PRDs, user stories, and requirements refinement.

But as I was building them, I kept coming back to everything we've been talking about today.

I don't want these tools to just do the thinking for us.

If the tool simply generates a polished PRD or a set of user stories and we accept it without questioning it, then we're right back in the same risk pattern.

So I've been trying to design the workflow to keep the human in the loop.

The skills are meant to prompt questions, surface assumptions, and guide more of a conversation instead of just producing a final answer.

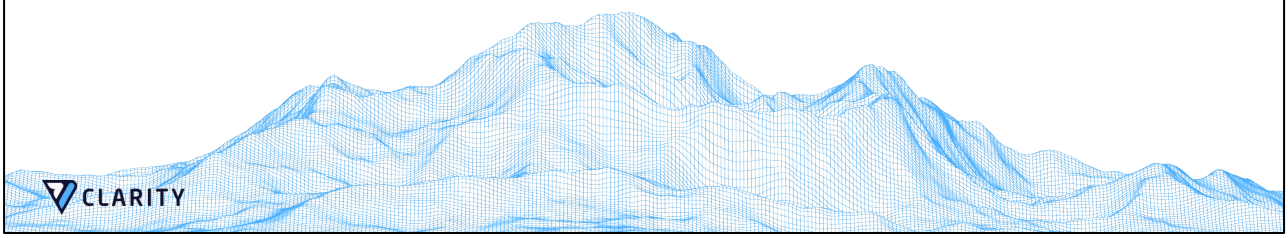
The goal is not, "AI writes the product work for us."

The goal is, "AI helps us think through the product work more clearly."

So as I show this, I want you to look not just at what the tool produces, but at where it asks for judgment, clarification, validation, and decision-making.

Reflection + Discussion

- Where are we most overconfident with AI?
- What still requires human judgment?
- What habits should we build as teams?



So that's a little bit of what I've been experimenting with from a workflow and tooling perspective.

And honestly, I don't think I have the perfect answer yet.

A lot of this still feels very early, and I think we're all collectively figuring out what healthy AI collaboration actually looks like in knowledge work.

But the more I use these systems, the more I think the important skill is probably not just learning how to prompt well.

It's learning how to stay thoughtful, reflective, and engaged while using them.

So I'd love to open this up a bit and hear how all of you are thinking about this in your own workflows and teams.



The biggest takeaway I hope people leave with is that confidence is not competence.

AI is an incredible accelerator, and honestly I think these tools are only going to become more integrated into the way we work. But responsible AI use requires more than procedural fluency. It requires judgment, reflection, validation, and conceptual understanding.

And the willingness to stay mentally engaged in the process.

I really think the future advantage won't come from simply using AI.

It will come from knowing when not to trust it.

Thanks everyone.